

## Why Share Food?

If one has extra food, why share it? What is the evolutionary advantage in that act that allowed sharing to develop in our prehuman ancestors and become common and eventually symbolically elaborate within our species? Gremillion outlines some of the evolutionary basics behind sharing by chimpanzees and other primates, using those arguments to illustrate why humans have shared food since the origin of our species. An important transition in human history, however, occurred with the advent of agriculture. It then became possible to grow food to feed more than the immediate family. As discussed earlier, one option then became storing extra food for future use. So, in a society where it is possible both to grow a surplus and to store that surplus, why share?

Anthropologists and archaeologists have tended toward social, rather than evolutionary, explanations for food sharing within agricultural societies. Extensive anthropological ethnographic studies of small-scale food-producing societies in the 19th and early 20th centuries generated considerable literature on food sharing. Especially prominent in the minds of anthropologists, due to its outsized social importance, was feasting.